

II2

Mordecai

The Jew at the king's gate who raised Esther, would not bow to Haman, and rose to be second only to the king.

Mordecai was a Jewish official in the Persian royal city of Shushan who raised his orphaned cousin Esther as his own daughter. From the king's gate he uncovered a plot to kill the king. When he refused to bow to Haman, Haman plotted to destroy all the Jews. Mordecai put on sackcloth and urged Esther to act "for such a time as this." In the end the king gave him Haman's place, and he wrote the decree that saved his people. He and Esther set up the feast of Purim.

At a glance

Name	Probably Babylonian; many link it to the god Marduk
Family	"The son of Jair ... the son of Kish, a Benjamite" (Esther 2:5)
Relation to Esther	Her cousin, who adopted her (Esther 2:7, 15)
Position	The king's gate; later "next unto king Ahasuerus"
When	Reign of Ahasuerus, usually Xerxes I (486–465 BC)
Key people	Esther, Ahasuerus, Haman, Hatach, Bigthan and Teresh
Main passages	Esther 2–10
New Testament	Not named

"For Mordecai the Jew was next unto king Ahasuerus, and great among the Jews, and accepted of the multitude of his brethren, seeking the wealth of his people, and speaking peace to all his seed."

Esther 10:3, KJV

The life of Mordecai

Dates approximate (BC). Esther 2:6 says someone "carried away" with Jeconiah in 597 BC: Mordecai himself or his great-grandfather Kish. If Mordecai, he would have been very old by Xerxes' reign.

- | | |
|--|---|
| Before Esther became queen | <p>● Adopts his cousin</p> <p>Mordecai brings up the orphaned Esther as his daughter and daily checks on her at the palace. <i>Esther 2:5-11</i></p> |
| c. 479-474 BC
<i>At the king's gate</i> | <p>● Saves the king's life</p> <p>He uncovers a plot by two doorkeepers. It is recorded, but he receives no reward. <i>Esther 2:19-23</i></p> |
| c. 474 BC
<i>12th year</i> | <p>● Refuses to bow</p> <p>The king promotes Haman and commands everyone at the gate to bow to him. Mordecai will not. When Haman learns that Mordecai is a Jew, he plots to destroy all the Jews. <i>Esther 3:1-6</i></p> |
| c. 474 BC
<i>The same month</i> | <p>● Sackcloth and a challenge</p> <p>Mordecai tears his clothes and cries out in the city. He sends Esther a copy of the decree and urges her to plead with the king: "who knoweth whether thou art come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" <i>Esther 4:1-17</i></p> |
| The night before the second banquet | <p>● Honoured by his enemy</p> <p>That night the sleepless king hears the record of Mordecai's loyalty and learns he was never rewarded. Haman, who came to ask for Mordecai's death, must lead him through the city on the king's horse. <i>Esther 6:1-12</i></p> |
| c. 474-473 BC
<i>Given Haman's place</i> | <p>● The new decree and Purim</p> <p>The king gives Mordecai the signet ring he took from Haman. Mordecai writes a decree letting the Jews defend themselves and goes out in royal robes. Afterwards he sends letters setting up the yearly feast of Purim. <i>Esther 8:1-2, 9-17; 9:20-23</i></p> |

Key activities

Why would Mordecai not bow? The text says only that "he had told them that he was a Jew" (Esther 3:4). Some think bowing to Haman seemed too close to worship. Others point to an old feud: Haman was an Agagite, perhaps descended from Agag, king of Amalek, while Mordecai came from the family of Kish, like King Saul (1 Samuel 15).

-
- 1 Adopted an orphan.** He took his cousin Esther "for his own daughter" when her parents died. *Esther 2:7*

 - 2 Watched over her.** He walked by the women's court every day "to know how Esther did." *Esther 2:11*

 - 3 Exposed a plot.** He uncovered a plan to kill the king and passed it on through Esther. *Esther 2:21-23*

 - 4 Refused to bow.** He would not bow to Haman, even when the king's servants pressed him day after day. *Esther 3:2-4*

 - 5 Mourned openly.** He put on sackcloth and ashes and "cried with a loud and a bitter cry." *Esther 4:1-2*

 - 6 Challenged Esther.** He warned her that silence would not save her and trusted that deliverance would come "from another place." *Esther 4:13-14*

 - 7 Stayed humble when honoured.** After his ride through the city in royal robes, he "came again to the king's gate." *Esther 6:10-12*

 - 8 Wrote the counter-decree.** With the king's ring he wrote letters allowing the Jews to stand for their lives. *Esther 8:9-11*

 - 9 Set up Purim.** He wrote to all the Jews to keep two days of feasting, gifts and "gifts to the poor" every year. *Esther 9:20-22*

 - 10 Worked for his people's good.** As second to the king, he sought "the wealth of his people." *Esther 10:3*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Mordecai.

Old Testament

Esther 2–10	This is the main account of his life.
Ezra 2:2	and Nehemiah 7:7 . A Mordecai returned with Zerubbabel. He is probably a different man.
Echoes	Like Joseph, Mordecai receives the king's ring, royal robes and a public parade (Genesis 41:42–43). His ancestor Kish shares a name with Saul's father (1 Samuel 9:1). "Whoso diggeth a pit shall fall therein" (Proverbs 26:27).

New Testament

Echoes	"Whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted" (Luke 14:11). Mary sings that God "hath put down the mighty from their seats" (Luke 1:52).
Tradition	By the time 2 Maccabees was written, in the second or first century BC, Purim was also called Mordecai's day (2 Maccabees 15:36, in the Apocrypha).

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Mordecai do each day after Esther was taken into the palace (Esther 2:11)?
- Understand:* Mordecai said deliverance would come "from another place" if Esther stayed silent. What does that show about his faith?
- Apply:* Mordecai raised a child who was not his own. Who could you invest in, encourage or look out for this month?
- Apply:* Mordecai's good deed went unrewarded for years. How do you keep doing right when no one notices?